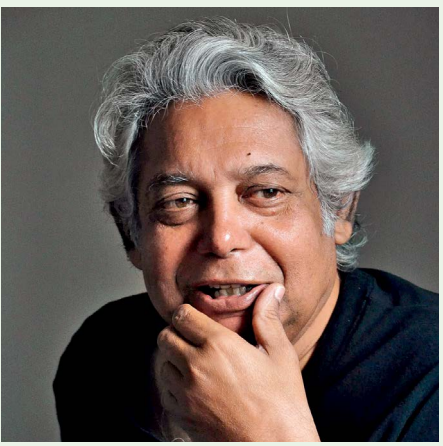




MANISH SINHA

PHOTOGRAPHY

WE ARE LIKE THIS ONLY

INDIANISMS, AN EXHIBITION OF PHOTOGRAPHS BY **PRASHANT PANJIAR** (*LEFT*), DOCUMENTS A VERNACULAR VISUAL LANGUAGE TYPICAL TO INDIA



SHOWING AT *Indianisms* is on at Museo Camera, Gurugram, till March 12. A section of the exhibition will travel to *The Month of Photography Tokyo* in June. There's also a show planned in Mumbai in September

Q. Your photo exhibition *Indianisms* is subtitled 'Observations of irony, ingenuity, irreverence, & idiosyncrasy in Indian life'. What drew you to capturing these ironies and idiosyncrasies?

A. I always draw upon my previous work to find new ways of moving ahead in photography. Looking through my older pictures, some even from the 1980s and '90s, I found a few idiosyncratic images of India. I decided to continue that kind of work. There was a period when I was very interested in kitsch which then transformed into looking at the public vernacular imagery that exists in India, marked by high use of colour, ironic juxtapositions, etc. I started seriously working on this in 2011 when I bought a camera that allowed me to shoot in a square format.

Q. How do 'Indianisms' as a concept translate into the visual realm?

A. The term 'Indianisms' was coined to describe our unique English usage, where we literally translate our thoughts from the vernacular, leading to the creation of phrases like 'please don't mind', 'we're like this only', 'mention not', 'please relish', etc. I've not tried to translate those words into images but rather used them as a reference [in the book that precedes the exhibition] for the visuals. I think they complement each other.

Q. What are the defining features of these images?

It could be all kinds of oddities, but not in a crude way. I don't think there are any defining 'Indianism' images. The only thing I had to be careful about was to avoid pictures that were clever. I weeded out a lot of my images and concentrated only on pictures that were intrinsically ironical or inventive.

Q. Which images are you especially fond of?

There's an image of a man drying his underwear on a stick (*bottom left*). That's the image that really started me on this journey. Then there's a photograph of an Ambedkar statue with the elephant symbol and balloons flying above. There's the picture of politicians on a discarded banner floating in a rice field (*top left*). It's also me having fun with the male gaze, including mine, like the image of the statue of a boy staring at the statue of a scantily clad woman.

Q. Where does *Indianisms* fit into your larger body of work?

Actually, it's quite different. I've been a photojournalist in some of the most traumatic decades in our recent history. That's the core of my work, very loaded and political. *Indianisms* is a departure. In fact, I was expecting some brickbats and people calling it completely non-serious work. But the reception's been good.

Q. Is it possible for journalistic images to also be artistic?

Absolutely. Without artistry, no photojournalistic image can endure. Look at the best and most iconic images of photojournalism from around the world and you'll find an underlying aesthetic language. [They] have moved people. How the work is presented, from the layout to the headlines and so on, also plays a crucial part. ■

–with Amit Dixit